

HIGH SOCIETY

European aristocrats had always been the primary patrons of luxury jewellery houses, but in the 20th century, with Europe ruined by war and political upheaval, jewellers turned to the new big spenders: the stars, socialites, and heiresses of America. These new clients not only had big budgets, but creative vision, too, since many of the super-rich buyers of fine jewellery were also trend-setters. Jeanne Toussaint was head designer of luxury jewels at Cartier from 1933 onwards, attracting commissions from some of the leading society women of the day: Wallis Simpson was a devoted client (see pp.224–25), as was Barbara Hutton, heiress to the Woolworths stores.

Rivalling Cartier and other traditional jewellery houses, geologist Harry Winston founded his own jewellery workshop in New York in 1932, and soon made a name for himself with his jaw-dropping gems. In 1944, he became the first jeweller to lend diamonds to an actress for the Academy Awards (Oscar-winner Jennifer Jones), thus securing his name among the stars of Hollywood and high society. Other famous clients included Richard Burton and Elizabeth Taylor (see p.297), and Jackie Kennedy.

**People will stare.
Make it worth
their while**

Harry Winston
Jeweller

King of Diamonds Harry Winston appealed to the women of American high society by sourcing spectacular gems and setting them in designs that would maximize their brilliance. His philosophy – to let the gemstones dictate the design – set the standard for high-end jewellery in the 1930s.

